BUSINESS

‘A 9-gigawatt problem’: Northwest’s soaring energy demand, supply constraints, could spark new power crisis

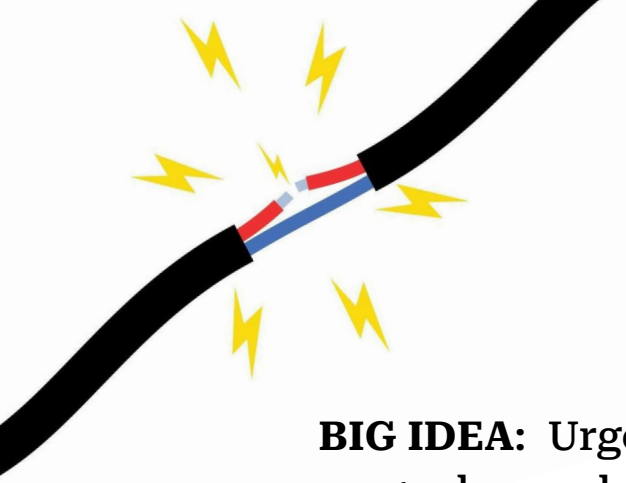
Updated: Jan. 23, 2026, 10:21 a.m. | Published: Jan. 11, 2026, 6:00 a.m.



The Power Griddy: Oregon Dances with Big Data

Energy-guzzling data centers
+
Clean energy mandates
=
Power crisis In Oregon
...leaving us vulnerable to severe shortages

By Aiyana Brown and Bradley Allen



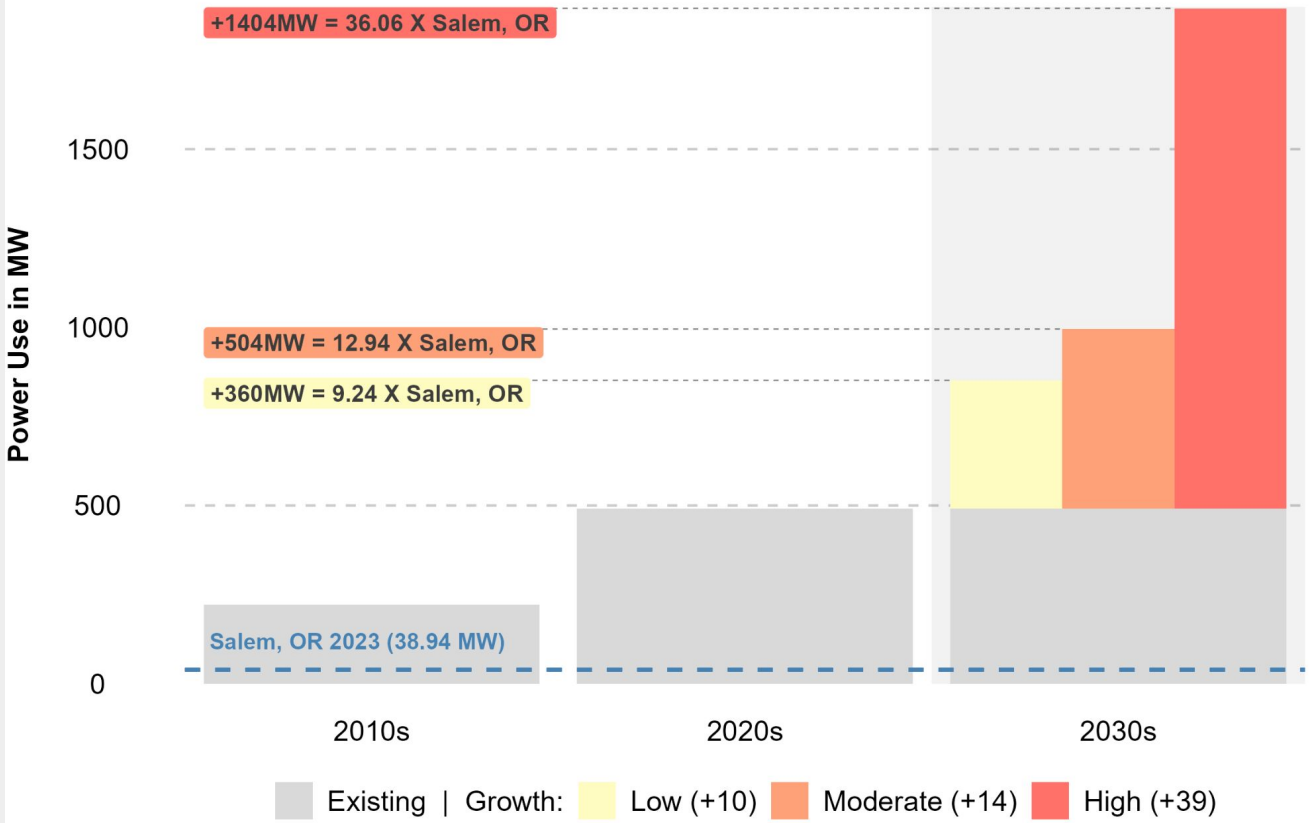
BIG IDEA: Urge policymakers to balance economic growth with energy demand and community needs when making plans for data centers and renewable mandates

AUDIENCE: Oregon Governor Tina Kotek and state legislators

Let’s dive deeper into this ‘9 Gigawatt Problem’

Shocking: Data Center Power Needs Dwarf Salem, OR Avg. Use

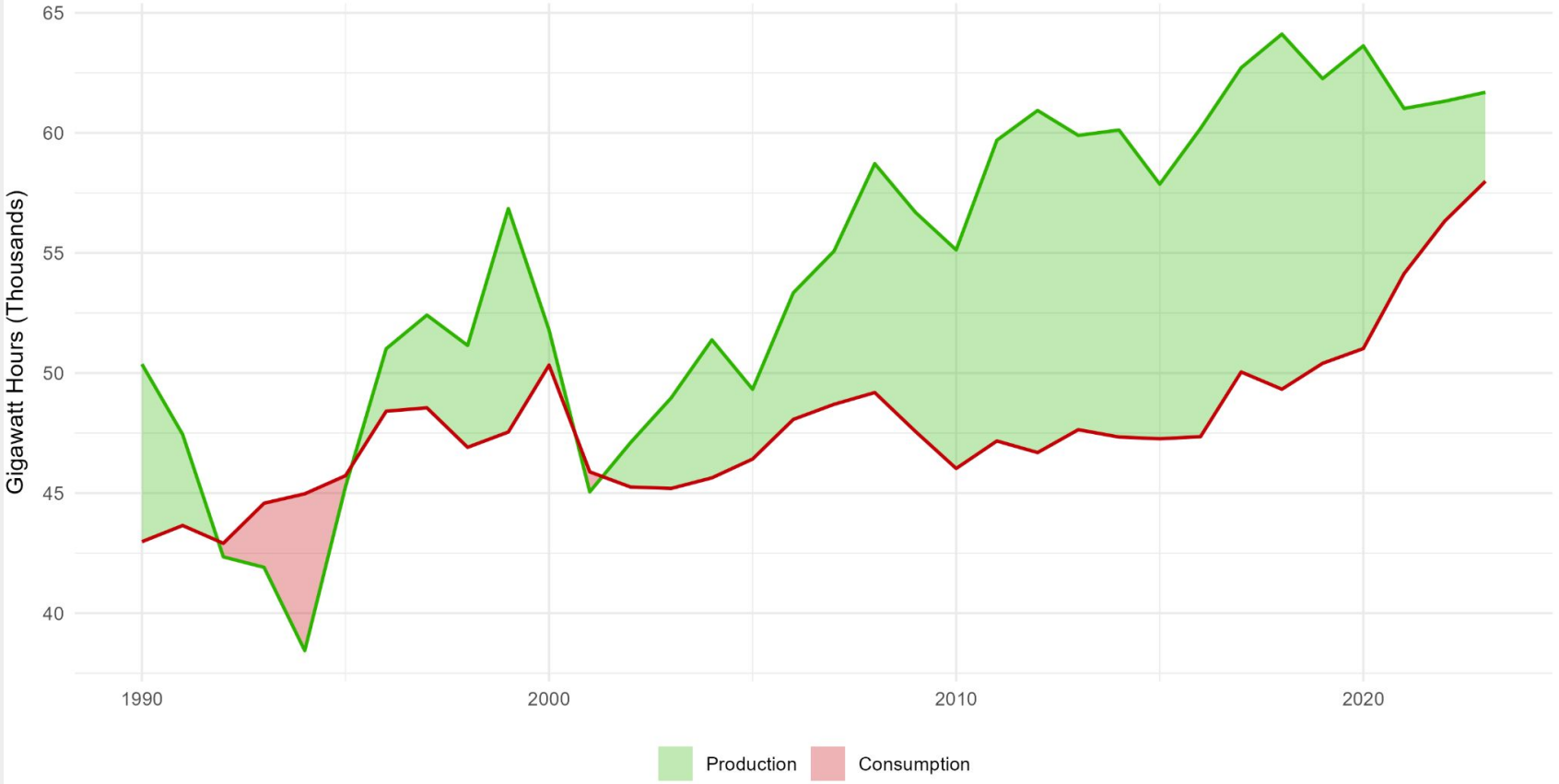
Running Total of Max. Power Consumption by Decade, Existing and Expected (2035)



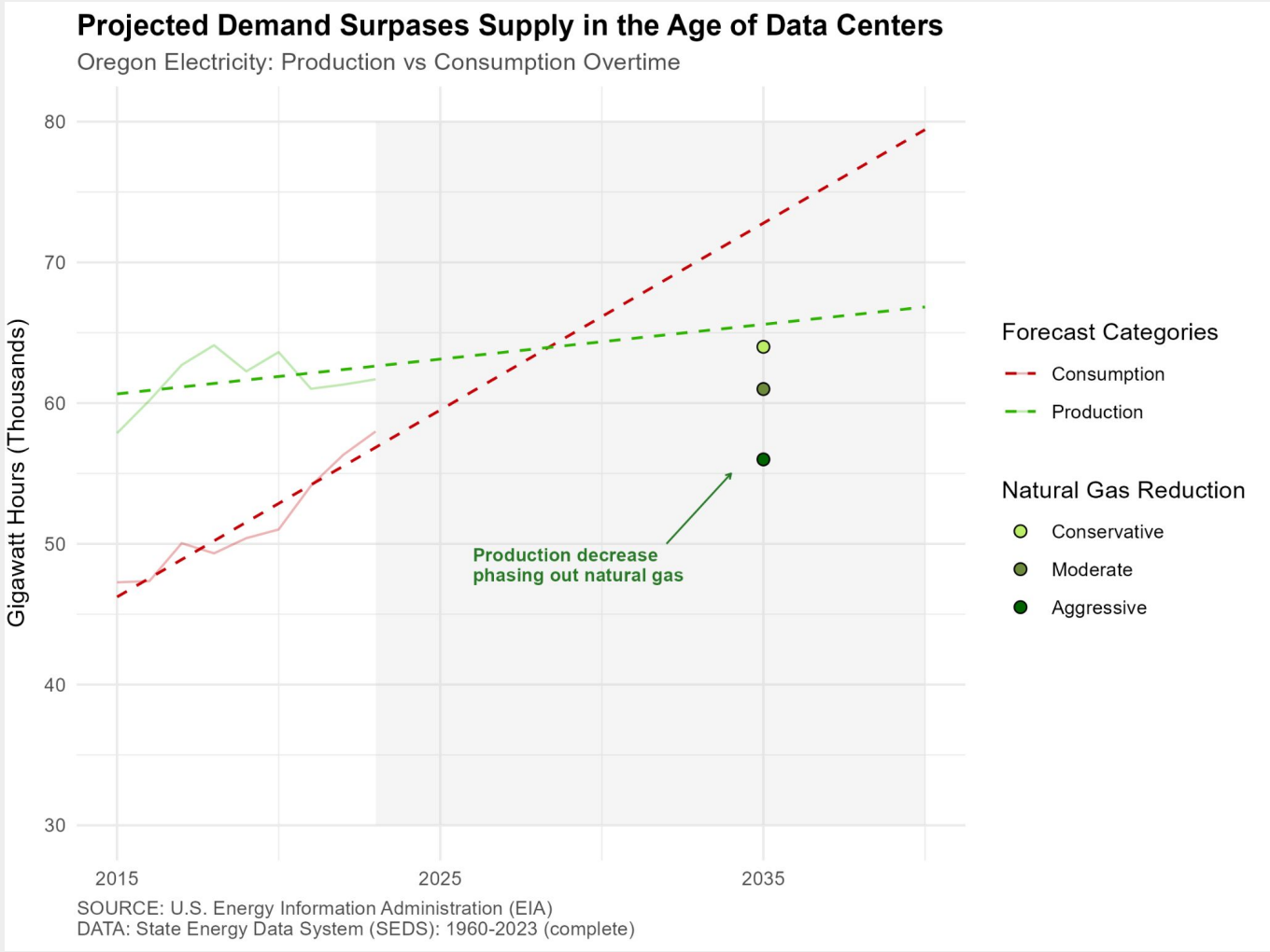
Sources: https://im3.pnnl.gov/datacenter-atlas
https://www.salemelectric.com/about-se/who-we-are/annual-report/

Age of Data Centers Transforms Energy Markets in Oregon

Oregon Electricity: Production vs Consumption Overtime

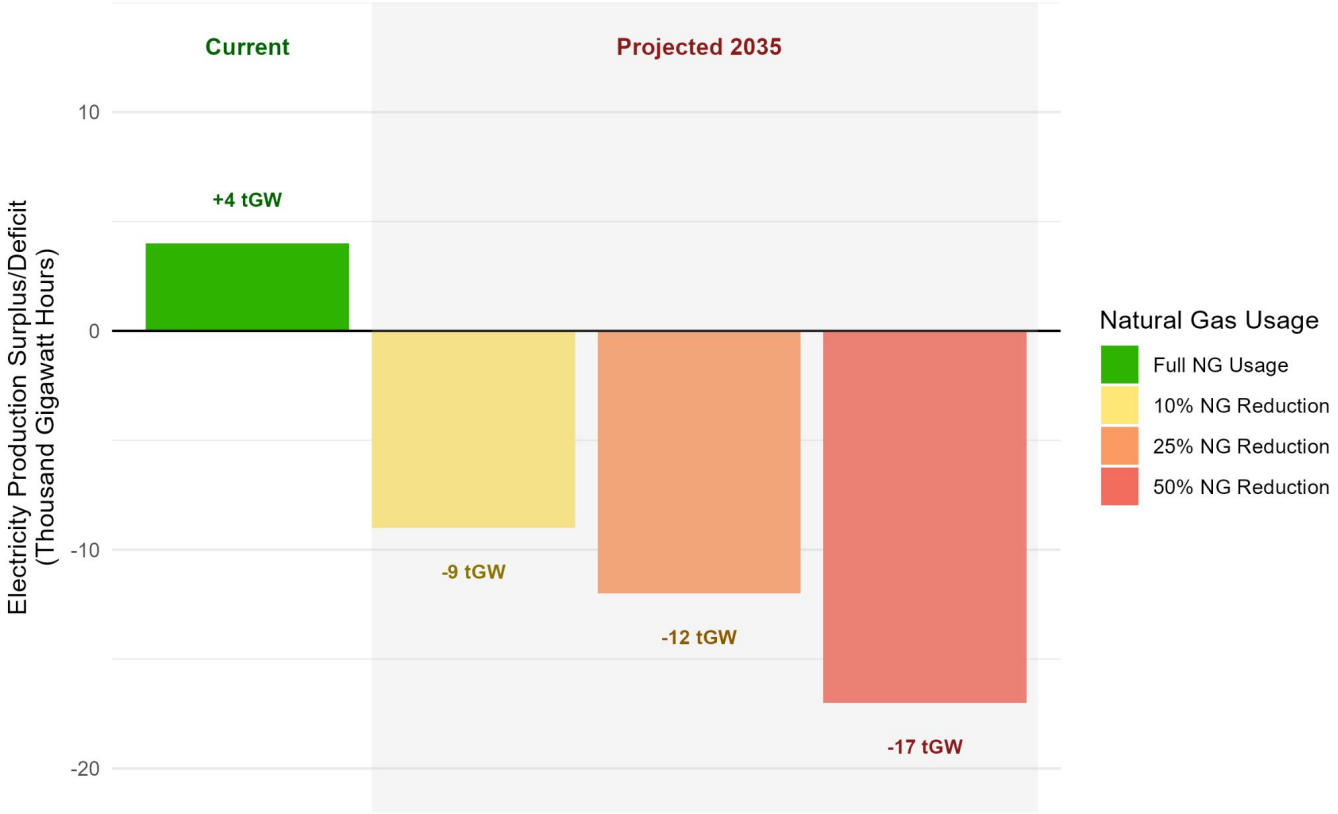


SOURCE: U.S. Energy Information Administration (EIA)
DATA: State Energy Data System (SEDS): 1960-2023 (complete)


Projected Demand Surpases Supply in the Age of Data Centers
Oregon Electricity: Production vs Consumption Overtime
Gigawatt Hours (Thousands)
80
70
60
50
40
30
2015
2025
2035
Production decrease
phasing out natural gas
Forecast Categories
Consumption
Production
Natural Gas Reduction
Conservative
Moderate
Aggressive
SOURCE: U.S. Energy Information Administration (EIA)
DATA: State Energy Data System (SEDS): 1960-2023 (complete)

Surplus to Shortage: Oregon Set To Be Net Deficit by 2035

Natural gas accounts for ~30% of Oregon's electricity production. If consumption follows recent trends, phasing out natural gas will create an electricity deficit, forcing Oregon to rely heavily on energy imports.



SOURCES: EIA, Oregon Live, Canary Media
DATA: State Energy Data System (SEDS): 1960-2023 (complete)

Sources

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